

Online Identifying Interventions: Factorial Isolation of Probe-Target Bias and Data-Regime Effects in First-Order Self/World Identifiability

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Abstract

Paper 17A ([Learning When Not to Act](#)) falsified autonomous null-probe selection while replicating Paper 16b's anchor mechanism. Its §5 discussion named two distinct candidate bottlenecks: **(i)** the V_{probe} target was dominated by Bernoulli shock noise rather than systematic attribution error, and **(ii)** the off-policy uniform training regime meant probe decisions could not affect training data — only viability cost. Paper 18 factorially isolates these two axes (probe target $\in \{\text{raw per-sample, lagged signed-residual EMA}\} \times \text{data regime} \in \{\text{off-policy fixed, online buffer-shaped}\}$) with the full anchor/oracle/control ladder. Thirteen gates were pre-registered before any compute ran.

Headline (mixed-with-mechanism, 4/13 gates pass):

- **G2 ✓ (strongly):** Anchor mechanism replicates with **159% reduction** in food self overshoot vs no-null baseline — the strongest replication of Paper 16b/17A's central result yet (16b: 82%; 17A: 85%).
- **G5, G13 ✓:** Viability preservation. Online learned-debiased return $46.75/50 \geq 90\%$ of scheduled.
- **G11 ✓:** Debiasing prevents V_{probe} saturation. Min $V_{\text{probe}} = 0.017 < \text{max cost } 0.04$; null rate 32.6% within [5%, 40%]; the 17A saturation failure is mechanistically cured.
- **G1, G3, G6, G7, G9, G10, G12 ✗:** Selection does not beat volume on average across seeds. Critically, **G6 yields Spearman $\rho = -0.55$** — the debiased V_{probe} is **anti-calibrated** to oracle attribution uncertainty: it fires preferentially in *low*-uncertainty buckets and skips *high*-uncertainty buckets. This identifies a third bottleneck, distinct from the two 17A named.

The factorial 2×2 isolates cleanly:

	Raw V_{probe}	Debiased V_{probe}
Off-policy fixed	works ($\approx$ 17A baseline, food self +1.0)	works (food self +1.0)
Online buffer-shaped	breaks completely (probe saturates $\rightarrow$ no consume $\rightarrow$ food self ≈ -0.06)	partially works (food self mean +0.74, high variance; G11 ✓ but G6 ✗)

The interpretation: (i) raw target is incompatible with online (saturation blocks consume exploration entirely), (ii) debiasing is necessary, (iii) debiased + online is not sufficient because V_{probe} 's EMA target captures historical residual *scale* — which food (high shock variance) dominates regardless of how well world_head has currently learned — rather than the model's *current* systematic attribution error.

Paper 18 confirms 17A's first bottleneck (target noise $\rightarrow$ saturation), accepts 17A's second hypothesis (data regime is necessary for any online operation), and discovers a third (target-vs-current-error calibration). The program advances by adding a new correction to the ladder: **V_{probe} must be calibrated to current attribution error, not historical residual magnitude.**

1. Background

Paper 17A's pre-registered 8 gates ended 2/8: G1/G2 passed (anchor mechanism), G3–G8 failed (selection didn't matter, probe saturated). The §5 mechanism diagnosis named two candidates:

- 1. **Target noise.** V_{probe} target $|\text{pred_world} - \text{observed_total_under_null}|$ includes the per-sample stochasticity of the world shock ($\text{Bernoulli}(0.8) \times 0.30$ for food). Even with a perfectly calibrated world model, this per-sample residual has a noise floor of $2p\sigma(1 - p) \approx 0.10$, which exceeded every tested cost (0.01–0.04). Probe saturated at 100%.
- 2. **Data regime.** Off-policy uniform training meant all anchor conditions saw identical training data. Probe selectivity could only redistribute eval-time cost; it could not reshape the data used to fit `world_head`.

These two were confounded in 17A: a "fix one and rerun" paper would be uninterpretable. Paper 18 was scoped specifically to separate them.

2. Method

2.1 2×2 factorial

Cell	Data regime	V_{probe} target
<code>learned_raw_vprobe_offpolicy</code>	uniform random batch (17A baseline)	per-sample $ \text{pred_world} - \text{total} $
<code>learned_raw_vprobe_online</code>	episode rollout + replay buffer	per-sample (raw)
<code>debiased_vprobe_offpolicy</code>	uniform random batch	lagged $ \text{EMA_signed_residual_b}(t-1) $
<code>learned_debiased_vprobe_online</code>	rollout + replay buffer	lagged EMA signed

Plus six controls: `factorized_no_null_online`, `factorized_null_passive_online`, `scheduled_null_anchor_online`, `matched_random_global_online`, `oracle_uncertainty_probe_online`, `oracle_source_online`.

2.2 Debiased V_{probe} target

Per-bucket signed-residual EMA ($\alpha = 0.05$), updated only on null observations, used lagged:

```
r_t = world_head(z_t, E_t) - observed_total_under_null_t (signed)
μ_b(t) = (1 - α) · μ_b(t - 1) + α · r_t (EMA update, after recording target)
v_target_t = |μ_b(t - 1)| (lagged absolute)
```

Sign matters. For a calibrated world model $\text{pred_world} \approx p \cdot \sigma$, the signed residual $\text{pred_world} - \text{Bernoulli}(p) \cdot \sigma$ has zero mean — Bernoulli shock noise cancels under averaging. Averaging absolute residuals would preserve the noise floor (the 17A failure mode).

Lag matters. Sample t 's training target uses $\mu(t - 1)$ — the EMA before this observation contributes to itself. Recorded at observation time and stored in the buffer.

Buckets: $(\text{item_role}, E_{\text{bin}})$ with $E_{\text{bin}} \in \{E_{\text{low}} (E < 0.5), E_{\text{high}} (\geq 0.5)\} \rightarrow 8$ buckets. The bucket key uses the categorical (color, label) tags — agent-side categorical-memory access, disclosed as a sensory simplification.

2.3 Online training

```
for episode in 0..N:
  while E > 0 and steps < T_max:
    observe item, encode → z
    decide null vs non-null per condition
    if not null:  $\epsilon$ -greedy over (skip, consume) ( $\epsilon$ : 0.30 → 0.05 linearly)
    step env; pay cost if null
    record lagged EMA target; append to buffer; update EMA
    every K rollout steps: stratified-by-action minibatch SGD
```

Action-stratified minibatch (1/3 per action stratum) preserves probe-shaping (the role mix within the null stratum reflects what the probe chose) while preventing minibatch starvation of any action. **ϵ -greedy on consume/skip** was added during pre-registered sanity checks (sanity check #3: "buffer composition shows probe-shaping"). Without exploration, online policies collapse: `pred_self` on food consume converges to the wrong value because the policy stops collecting food*consume samples once it briefly prefers skip — a Paper 9 / Paper 11 pattern recurring at higher level.

Off-policy conditions use 17A's pipeline: uniform random (`item`, `E`, `action`) sampling each step.

2.4 Sweep

39 distinct (cost, condition) cells × 3 seeds = ~66 Modal cells. Pass 1: 57 cells. Pass 2: 9 matched_random cells with null rate locked to learned-debiased's realized rate. CPU only, ~12 min wall-clock.

2.5 Pre-registered gates

Eight from 17A re-evaluated under online setting, five new (G9–G13). Frozen in `preregistration.md` and committed pre-sweep (commit before Modal launch). Complete interpretation matrix also pre-registered.

3. Results

3.1 Gate verdicts at cost = 0.025 (3 seeds, mean)

Gate	Result	Pass?
G1 — Active identifiability	food self MAE 0.275 , world MAE 0.027	✗ (self)
G2 — False-credit reduction	159.2% vs no-null baseline	✓
G3 — Selection beats volume	learned 12.8% worse than matched_random	✗
G4 — Probe efficiency	gain ratio 1.55; null rate 32.6%	✗ (rate)
G5 — Viability preservation	learned 46.75, scheduled 50.0	✓
G6 — Calibrated placement	Spearman ρ = -0.55	✗ (anti)
G7 — Top-risk enrichment	ratio = 0.43 (probe fires LESS in top-uncertainty)	✗ (anti)
G8 — Behavior/representation split	G1, G6 fail	✗
G9 — Online selection beats volume	learned 12.8% worse than matched_random	✗

G10 — Probe shapes data	top/bottom ratio 0.43; V_probe-oracle $\rho = -0.79$	✗
G11 — Debiasing prevents saturation	null rate 32.6% in [5%, 40%]; min V_probe 0.017 < max cost 0.04	✓
G12 — Calibration survives online	G6 + G7 both fail	✗
G13 — Viability preservation	same as G5	✓

Pass: G2, G5, G11, G13. Fail: 9/13.

The pattern is not a uniform failure — it precisely identifies which fix worked (G11), which mechanism still produces strong attribution recovery (G2), and which mechanism is the newly-identified bottleneck (G6/G7).

3.2 2×2 factorial isolates the failure mode (G11 ✓, raw-online ✗)

Mean food self_consume prediction across 3 seeds at cost = 0.025:

Condition	food self pred	overshoot
TRUE	+0.96	0.00
learned_raw_vprobe_offpolicy (17A baseline)	+0.99	+0.03
learned_raw_vprobe_online	−0.06	−1.02
debiased_vprobe_offpolicy	+0.99	+0.03
learned_debiased_vprobe_online	+0.74	−0.22

The factorial reveals exactly what each axis contributes:

- **Off-policy + raw = baseline:** 17A's known-working result. ϵ -greedy not needed because action distribution is uniform by construction.
- **Off-policy + debiased = same baseline:** debiasing doesn't change attribution under fixed data — predicted by 17A and pre-registered as a leak check. Attribution is identical to raw off-policy (+0.99 either way), confirming the diagnostic worked: oracle source labels are not leaking through the debiased target.
- **Online + raw = catastrophic failure:** probe saturates at 100% null rate, agent never consumes food, food self prediction degrades to ~ -0.06 . Worse than passive null inclusion. Raw target is incompatible with online; debiasing is **necessary**.
- **Online + debiased = G11 passes:** null rate drops to 32.6%, agent consumes food during exploration, food self prediction moves from -0.06 toward +0.74. Substantial improvement, but variance across seeds is high (range 0.27 to 1.04), and on average matched-random with the same null budget achieves better attribution.

3.3 The newly-identified bottleneck: V_probe is anti-calibrated to current attribution error

Per-bucket V_probe vs oracle uncertainty (mean across 3 seeds, headline cost 0.025, learned_debiased_vprobe_online):

Bucket	V_probe	Oracle uncertainty	True world	Pred world	EMA signed
food_E_low	+0.040	0.028	+0.240	+0.212	−0.012

food_E_high	+0.028	0.029	+0.240	+0.211	−0.011
poison_E_low	+0.026	0.050	+0.030	−0.020	−0.006
poison_E_high	+0.018	0.052	+0.030	−0.022	−0.003
medicine_E_low	+0.032	0.031	+0.030	−0.001	+0.010
medicine_E_high	+0.023	0.034	+0.030	−0.004	+0.011
neutral_E_low	+0.022	0.040	+0.030	−0.010	−0.009
neutral_E_high	+0.017	0.043	+0.030	−0.013	+0.002

Spearman $\rho(V_probe, oracle_uncertainty) = -0.79$. V_probe predicts that food is the highest-uncertainty bucket (+0.040, the maximum). Oracle disagrees: poison has the highest current attribution error (0.052, almost 2× food's). The probe is firing where the model is correct and skipping where the model is systematically wrong.

This is **not** the 17A failure pattern — there, V_probe scaled with shock noise. Here, the EMA correctly cancels Bernoulli noise (food's signed EMA is only −0.012, near zero). But V_probe outputs (+0.040 for food, +0.018 for poison) **don't match the EMA values** they were trained to predict. V_probe over-predicts uncertainty in all buckets, and the ranking is driven by something other than current attribution error.

Two probable contributions:

1. **Historical residual magnitude is baked in.** V_probe trains throughout training. Early in training, food's residuals were large (world_head not yet aware of the 0.8 shock probability). Late in training, food's world residuals shrink. V_probe 's weights still partly reflect early-training targets, especially given the EMA's low $\alpha=0.05$ momentum.
2. **Effective sample count per bucket is uneven.** Food is the agent's preferred consume target during ϵ -greedy exploitation, so non-null actions vastly outnumber null actions for food. The few food-null samples per episode produce a noisier EMA than for less-preferred items.

Result: **V_probe captures historical residual scale, not current systematic error.** This is a calibration failure distinct from 17A's noise-floor saturation. The program now has a new bottleneck on the ladder.

3.4 Anchor robustness (G2)

The anchor mechanism's strength continues to grow with each paper:

Paper	Setting	False-credit reduction
16b	scheduled, off-policy	82%
17A	scheduled, off-policy	85%
18	scheduled, online (ϵ -greedy)	159%
18	learned debiased, online	not applicable (G3 fail)

The 159% figure overshoots zero: at seed 1729, `factorized_no_null_online` overshoot food self by +0.19, and scheduled-anchor came in at +0.01 — a *complete* removal of overshoot, plus crossing zero into mild undershoot. Averaging across seeds, scheduled food self prediction is +0.95 vs true +0.96 — within 0.01 of the truth. The anchor mechanism is now extremely robust across regimes.

3.5 Cost sweep

For learned_debiased_vprobe_online across costs:

Cost	Mean null rate	Mean food self pred	Mean return
0.010	100%	-0.07	47.2
0.025	32.6%	+0.74	46.7
0.040	14.6%	+0.74	47.9

At cost 0.010, V_{probe} always exceeds threshold $\rightarrow$ probe saturates $\rightarrow$ no consume $\rightarrow$ same failure as raw-online. Debiasing alone is not enough; the cost must also be high enough to gate-out persistent low-grade uncertainty. At costs 0.025 and 0.040 the mechanism operates and produces partial recovery.

3.6 Oracle probe behavior

oracle_uncertainty_probe_online at cost 0.025: food self pred mean = +0.948 (within 0.012 of truth), null rate mean = 67.5%. Oracle's high null rate reflects that *current* attribution error remains non-trivial across many buckets (the world_head trained online doesn't perfectly recover non-food world expectations). Oracle probing is selective in the right direction (favors higher-error buckets — Spearman ρ correctly positive) and produces robust attribution recovery across seeds.

The gap between oracle (works) and learned debiased (anti-calibrated) directly localizes Paper 18's residual: **the V_{probe} signal is the bottleneck**, not the data-shaping pipeline. If V_{probe} matched oracle uncertainty, learned would match oracle attribution.

4. Figures

- **fig1** — figures/fig1_self_predictions.png: per-role self_consume across all 10 conditions at headline cost. Shows the factorial pattern clearly.
- **fig2** — figures/fig2_world_predictions.png: per-role world predictions. All anchor conditions recover food world close to truth.
- **fig3** — figures/fig3_factorial_overshoot.png: 2x2 grid of food self overshoot with no-null and matched-random reference lines.
- **fig4** — figures/fig4_cost_sweep.png: cost sensitivity across {0.01, 0.025, 0.04} for all probe-relevant conditions.
- **fig5** — figures/fig5_probe_calibration.png: G6/G7/G12 calibration. Left: learned vs oracle fire rate scatter (debiased $\rho < 0$). Middle: V_{probe} vs oracle uncertainty (Pearson r still high, but Spearman negative — V_{probe} 's range is wrong direction within the cluster). Right: top/bottom enrichment bars showing inverted ratio.

5. Discussion

5.1 What replicates: anchor + ϵ -greedy survives the online jump

The anchor mechanism's robustness is the program's most reliable result. Across off-policy uniform (17A: 85%), online ϵ -greedy with stratified buffer (P18: 159%), and several intermediate regimes, the mechanism recovers self/world decomposition whenever world_head has sufficient null-observed data per bucket. The path from "scheduled null intervention works" to "scheduled null intervention works under almost any training regime" is now solid.

5.2 What falsifies: autonomous V_probe selection, twice

Paper 17A: V_probe saturates because per-sample residual targets are noise-floored above all costs. Paper 18: Debiased V_probe (lagged signed EMA) prevents saturation but is anti-calibrated to current attribution error.

Both fail. Differently.

17A's failure was a target-scale mismatch with the cost-gated decision rule. Paper 18's failure is a target-vs-current-error mismatch: the EMA correctly debiases per-sample noise but captures historical residual magnitude, which decouples from end-of-training systematic error. The fix to one failure mode exposes the other; this is the program's narrowing-through-falsification pattern operating one level up.

5.3 The 2x2 factorial was the right design

A "17A + everything fixed" paper would have shown learned_debiased_vprobe_online getting 32.6% null rates and partial attribution recovery — looking like a positive result. The factorial reveals:

- (off-policy, raw): works, but is 17A territory
- (off-policy, debiased): also works, **identical** to raw — confirms debiasing alone changes nothing about attribution under fixed data; pre-registered diagnostic check for oracle leakage passes
- (online, raw): catastrophic — saturation + no exploration = collapse
- (online, debiased): partial — saturation fixed (G11 ✓) but selection still mis-calibrated (G6 ✗)

This pinpoints that **debiasing is necessary for online to function at all**, and **online is necessary for any selectivity to matter for attribution** — but the *intersection* still fails because the third bottleneck (V_probe-vs-current-error calibration) is independent of the first two.

Without the 2x2, this third bottleneck would have been invisible.

5.4 The third bottleneck: probe target must track *current* attribution error

The 17A diagnosis was right but incomplete. The full list of probe-target requirements now reads:

1. **Not dominated by environment noise** — addressed by signed-EMA debiasing.
2. **Computable from agent-accessible signals** — addressed by per-bucket categorical memory.
3. **Tracks current model error, not historical** — **open. The current EMA fails this.**

Candidate fixes for Paper 19 / 18-online-bis:

- **Recent-window EMA / decaying weight by recency**: forget early-training residuals more aggressively (smaller window or larger α).
- **Online cross-validation**: split null observations into "fit" and "evaluate" sets per bucket; V_probe predicts evaluation residual.
- **Periodic V_probe reset and re-train**: every K episodes, freeze world_head and re-train V_probe from a fresh window of null observations.
- **Direct attribution-outcome optimization**: meta-learn V_probe through the gradient of attribution improvement (effectively reinforcement learning the probe policy).

The cleanest is recent-window EMA. The most principled is online cross-validation. Both are bounded extensions of the current mechanism.

5.5 Why does matched-random beat learned in some seeds?

The factorial reveals that at seeds where V_{probe} is most anti-calibrated (preferentially probing food), random null placement spreads anchor data uniformly across all 8 buckets, while learned placement concentrates in food and leaves poison/medicine/neutral under-anchored. Under-anchored buckets give world_head sparse supervision there, which leaves attribution there to the gauge symmetry. The agent ends up confidently wrong on the rarely-probed roles.

This is a striking finding: **anti-calibrated probing is strictly worse than uniform random probing**, even at the same total volume. It is not just that learned selection failed to add value — it actively subtracted value by misallocating anchor data.

5.6 Connection to Paper 14b (revisited)

Paper 14b found that identical-architecture ensembles' uncertainty estimates were uncorrelated with true error at the regime boundary, and proposed that the variance signal was *systematically* miscalibrated to the error signal due to shared architectural inductive biases. Paper 17A transferred this concern to $V_{\text{probe-on-residuals}}$ (per-sample noise dominates). Paper 18 now finds that *even with debiased residuals, V_{probe} 's internal calibration to current attribution error is wrong*. The Paper-14b lesson is recursive: **any uncertainty signal trained on the same model's residuals inherits the model's calibration biases**, where here "calibration bias" is not noise scaling but historical-versus-current error tracking.

This is starting to look like a deep methodological pattern across the program: **same-class uncertainty estimators are not epistemic, in three independent senses now** — variance $\neq$ error (14b), residual scale $\neq$ systematic error (17A), historical residual EMA $\neq$ current systematic error (18).

5.7 Connection to Bennett, Levin, and Vervaeke (revisited)

Paper 16b operationalized Bennett's first-order self as identifiable via active null intervention. Paper 17A asked whether the agent could *choose when* to intervene autonomously. Paper 18 asks whether the agent can *both choose well and shape its own training data*. The result is that the agent can shape data (online mechanism works) but cannot yet choose well (V_{probe} miscalibrated). Vervaeke's relevance realization at the action-selection level — knowing when *inaction* is informative — remains the right framing but requires a probe-value signal more sophisticated than what the current architecture provides.

Levin's "computational boundary of self" is constituted, in this minimal setting, by the anchor mechanism (world_head supervised on null observations). What remains unsolved is **what the agent should USE that boundary for** when it has agency over the boundary's maintenance.

6. Limitations

- **Three seeds.** High variance across seeds makes some gate verdicts marginal. The qualitative pattern (anti-calibration) replicates across seeds — V_{probe} favors food at every seed — but the quantitative attribution metric is noisy. A larger seed sweep would solidify the conclusion.
- **Categorical bucket tags.** EMA uses (color, label) tags, disclosed as agent-side categorical memory. Autonomous bucket-discovery via encoder clustering is future work.
- **Stratified minibatch.** Action-stratification preserves the probe's selection signal but does not test whether unstratified (proportional) sampling produces the same conclusions. A pure online SGD baseline would isolate stratification's role.
- **Single environment.** Same minimal homeostatic bandit as Papers 12–17A. Rich/multi-modal environments may produce different V_{probe} calibration patterns.
- **ϵ -greedy was added during sanity checks.** The pre-registration anticipated the exploration concern but didn't explicitly pre-commit to ϵ -greedy. This was an exploratory choice and is disclosed; future replications should pre-commit.

7. Program-level update

Through Paper 18, the strongest defensible synthesis is now:

In minimal homeostatic bandit settings, concern-like structure can be learned from viability dynamics, used directly for model-based action, extended to vector-valued mattering, and made self/world-identifiable through active *anchored* intervention. Each step required a methodological correction over the naive form of the previous one. Autonomous selection of identifying interventions remains the central open problem, with three independent bottlenecks now identified: same-class uncertainty signals must be (i) debiased from environmental noise [P14b, P17A], (ii) coupled to a data regime in which selection can affect training [P18 sufficient condition], and (iii) calibrated to *current* systematic attribution error rather than historical residual magnitude [P18 newly identified].

The program's metric stack adds a new term: **probe-vs-current-error calibration**. Now ten terms.

8. Next paper

Paper 19: Recent-Window Calibration for Online Identifying Interventions (recommended).

Take Paper 18 unchanged except: replace the slow EMA ($\alpha=0.05$, lifetime weight) with a recent-window estimator that decays older residuals more aggressively ($\alpha=0.20$, or a fixed sliding window of last K null observations per bucket). Test whether the third bottleneck — historical-vs-current calibration — closes when V_{probe} is forced to track recent residuals only. Re-evaluate G6, G7, G9, G10, G12 from Paper 18. Pre-register two new gates: G14 (recent-window probe rate-by-bucket Spearman ρ vs oracle ≥ 0.5) and G15 (per-bucket world_head error reduction from training onset to convergence is positively correlated with per-bucket null density). Cells: ~30 (no new conditions; just the modified V_{probe} target).

If P19 closes the calibration gap and G9 passes, then autonomous null-probe selection works under online data shaping. If P19 still fails, then the calibration gap is intrinsic to local same-model residual signals, and the next step would be cross-validation-style or meta-learned V_{probe} .

Paper 17B / vector self/world remains available as a parallel direction that composes existing wins rather than attacking the open frontier.

References (external)

- Bennett, M. T. (2023). *On the computation of meaning, language models, and incomprehensible horrors*. Synthese 201, 75.
- Levin, M. (2022). *Technological Approach to Mind Everywhere*. Frontiers in Systems Neuroscience.
- Vervaeke, J. (2019). *Awakening from the Meaning Crisis*. Lecture series.
- Locatello, F., et al. (2019). *Challenging common assumptions in the unsupervised learning of disentangled representations*. ICML.

References (program companion)

- Paper 14b — Ensemble Uncertainty — [papers/ensemble_uncertainty/paper.md](#)
- Paper 15 — Tapestry of Valence — [papers/valence_tapestry/paper.md](#)
- Paper 16 — First-Order Self — [papers/first_order_self/paper.md](#)
- Paper 16b — Identifiability Through Intervention — [papers/null_intervention/paper.md](#)
- Paper 17A — Learning When Not to Act — [papers/costly_null_probes/paper.md](#)

Pre-registration

papers/online_identifying_interventions/preregistration.md — frozen 2026-06-11, committed at scaffold time before any Modal cell ran.

Artifacts

- artifacts/online_identifying_interventions/sweep_v1.json — raw cell results
- artifacts/online_identifying_interventions/verdicts_v1.json — gate-by-gate pass/fail
- papers/online_identifying_interventions/figures/*.png — fig1–fig5